Presented by Aobscura Games
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GAMES
DEVELOPMENT PLAN
DREADWOODS PROJECT
https://apokriptos.github.io/aobscuragames/
01

DEVELOPMENT CONTEXT & CONSTRAINTS

01

Dreadwoods is an independent collaboration between three core creators. The project is currently represented by Aobscura Games while its long-term production structure remains open.

02

The current team covers game design, Blueprint development, animation, writing, project management and UI/UX, allowing the prototype to validate the complete gameplay logic internally.

03

The main production gap is original asset creation—especially 3D character, creature and environment modeling—alongside additional animation capacity for a heavily authored experience.

04

The project deliberately favors a smaller number of bespoke chapters over content volume. Narrative, animation and sequence choreography must receive enough production time to preserve quality.

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PRODUCTION STRATEGY

The project is aiming at a 150k-250k initial funding. The immediate objective is to find a publishing or production partner who can help move Dreadwoods from a proven gameplay prototype to a production-quality vertical slice.

Partner support would prioritize core-team production time, original 3D asset production, additional animation capacity, audio/music/VFX, and technical or production support where needed.

Once the vertical slice validates the project at production quality, full-production scope and financing can be defined from a stronger shared baseline.

MARKET POSITIONING & PLATFORM STRATEGY

PLATFORM

Dreadwoods is planned as a premium single-player PC release, with consoles considered after the PC production path is established.

TARGET AUDIENCE

The intended full experience is compact—approximately 8–10 hours—and targets players who enjoy narrative horror, dark fantasy, cinematic character interaction, exploration and puzzle-solving.

Its visual and tonal identity draws loosely from Latin American and Slavic folkloric traditions which, merged together, form a cohesive original fantasy.

AUTHORED SCOPE

Production quality per zone is prioritized over level count. Each zone depends on bespoke dialogue, animation, puzzles, sequence choreography and environmental storytelling.

Reference points include Hellblade for cinematic intensity, The Witcher 3 for authored character interaction, Darkwood for folkloric unease, World of Warcraft for readable fantasy spaces, and Labyrinth for its unsettling fairy-tale journey.

MILESTONES & PRODUCTION PATH

Dreadwoods is advancing towards a playable vertical slice.

EVA 2026 — Present the current gameplay proof and establish publishing and production conversations.

UNREAL MEETUP — Two weeks later, deliver a 10–15 minute micro-demo showing the full loop from first Beast encounter to finding the Witch, unlocking all three powers and escaping the final sequence.

VERTICAL SLICE — Produce one complete chapter at production quality with polished sequence spaces, cinematic dialogue, branching local solutions, signature original characters and creatures, and cohesive audiovisual direction.

FULL PRODUCTION — Define final team structure, budget and game scope with a partner after the slice validates the project.

DREADWOODS ROADMAP

2026-2027: from prototype to vertical slice

PRE-PRODUCTION

- Lock vertical-slice level scope
- Finalize power, Dread & sequence implementations
- Set production art/animation pipeline
- Set asset and staffing needs

MILESTONES

- Slice design and content map locked
- Sequence tools and pipelines assembled
- Original asset briefs approved

OCT — DEC 2026

CORE PRODUCTION

- Produce Beast, Witch, NPC & creature assets
- Build authored sequence spaces and quests
- Expand dialogue, animation and environment work
- Integrate audio/VFX/UI foundations

MILESTONES

- Core original characters in production
- Main chapter playable end-to-end
- Key animation and sequence sets integrated
- Production pipeline validated

JAN — SEP 2027

REVIEW & TRANSITION

- Finalize and package the vertical slice
- Present to publishers and production partners
- Define full-production budget, team and scope

MILESTONES

- Polished vertical slice delivered
- Partner and funding conversations advanced
- Full-production plan and budget defined
- 2028 roadmap set from financing outcome

OCT — DEC 2027

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GAME DESIGN

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GAME DESIGN — KEY OBJECTIVES

A Lock the core loop and interaction rules for Slow, Reverse and the Dread-breaking movement power across authored sequence elements.

B Define clear affordances: most sequence-driven elements are manipulable; runes and special materials signal immunity.

C Design branching local solutions in which dialogue, quests, prior actions and NPC assistance alter routes or conditions inside later encounters.

D Design the forest's behaviors to properly convey its magical, mischievous nature as both a source of obstacles and opportunities.

GAME DESIGN

Focus

Dreadwoods is built around manipulating authored sequences. Slow, Reverse and a Dread-breaking movement power let players interfere with eligible actors, obstacles and supernatural entities while preserving deliberate encounter design.

2026 Priorities

Current design work focuses on validating the complete gameplay loop, combining powers cleanly, clarifying energy and Dread rules, and making sequence manipulation readable.

Player Agency

Agency is reflected in the different ways players can interpret, choose and solve challenges. Dialogue choices, quests, routes and prior favors can alter information, access and assistance available inside later sequences.

Difficulty & Accessibility

Challenge is based on observation, timing, exploration and puzzle-solving. Failure during major encounters returns the player to another attempt through the fiction of fate being reset rather than a conventional death screen.

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LEVEL DESIGN

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LEVEL DESIGN

LEVEL DESIGN — KEY OBJECTIVES

A Build and polish the 10–15 minute Unreal Meetup micro-demo, including all three power-learning sections and the Beast encounter.

B Establish repeatable design rules for sequence spaces so choreography, geometry and manipulable actors remain readable and reliable.

C Create exploration puzzle chains that combine NPC quests, riddles, environmental clues and supernatural obstacles on the route to the Witch.

D Define navigation and branching-route principles that support getting lost without making progression arbitrary or dependent on excessive UI.

E Produce one complete vertical-slice chapter that serves as the quality and structural template for future zones.

LEVEL DESIGN

Structure

The game is structured as distinct forest zones connected by transitions. Each zone is a highly authored area with its own inhabitants, puzzles and supernatural threats, while finding the Witch is the main goal in order to overcome the Beast Sequence.

2026 Scope

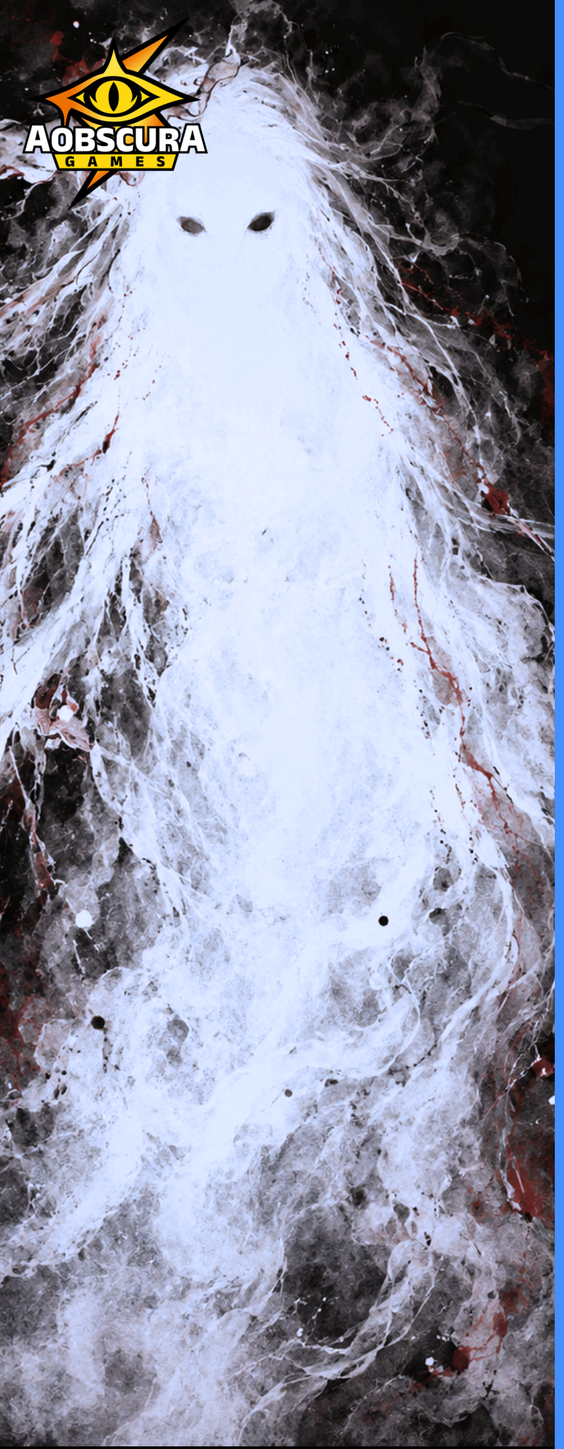
The near-term scope is the Unreal Meetup micro-demo followed by one production-quality vertical-slice level. The slice will showcase all three powers even though the full game is expected to introduce powers progressively across later zones.

Gameplay Loop

A level can be played through exploration, dialogue, quests, riddles and supernatural obstacles, but ultimately builds toward finding the Witch, gaining new power, and confronting the Beast sequence that leads into the next zone.

Guidance & Pacing

Dedicated sequence spaces are physically authored sections built around major encounters. Navigation should feel uncertain and folkloric while still using readable landmarks, environmental cues and carefully controlled trigger areas.



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DEV — KEY OBJECTIVES

A Formalize the shared sequence-manipulation framework for Slow, Reverse and Dread-breaking movement across all eligible actors.

B Refine cinematic dialogue, quests, map objectives and NPC-assistance hooks so choices can reliably influence later sequences.

C Improve feedback for Dread, limited power energy, eligibility and immunity so players understand what can be manipulated and why.

D Set up the main workflow through custom tools that let level designers and animators safely build sequence-driven interactions.

E Profile, test and modularize the prototype systems for vertical-slice reliability.

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DEV

Focus

Dreadwoods is currently developed in Unreal Engine using Blueprints. Technical work supports sequence manipulation, cinematic branching dialogue, quests, map objectives, supernatural states, and the hooks that let earlier player actions affect later encounters.

2026 Scope

The immediate technical priority is turning proven prototype systems into a stable micro-demo and then a vertical slice.

Technical Philosophy

Sequence manipulation is deliberately authored: powers operate as area effects on eligible tagged elements, while explicit immunity materials and runes preserve designer control. Blueprint systems should remain modular and understandable to future collaborators.

Constraints & Sustainability

The main technical constraint is content complexity rather than feature count. Animation, Sequencer choreography and branching hooks require clean conventions so artists and designers can add content without destabilizing encounters.

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ANIMATION → ANIMATION → ANIMATION

ANIMATION — KEY OBJECTIVES

A Complete the Beast sequence choreography, including pursuit, capture, interrupted death and retry transitions.

B Build cinematic response-animation sets for the key NPC dialogue scenes used in the micro-demo and vertical slice.

C Animate the Witch’s masked manifestation, her guardians and the supernatural entities required by the first chapter.

D Develop environmental animation for moving trees, reactive obstacles and other sequence-driven forest elements.

E Establish a scalable animation pipeline and expand animator capacity as the project moves toward a full vertical slice.

ANIMA-TION

Role in the Experience

Animation is a core production dependency in Dreadwoods. Cinematic dialogue, supernatural entities, the Beast, sequence choreography and reactive environmental elements all rely on authored movement to sell the fantasy.

2026 Scope

The current milestone requires a polished animation set for the micro-demo. The vertical slice expands this into production-quality dialogue performances, Beast choreography, supernatural encounters and environmental animation.

Style & Direction

Animation should feel stylized, expressive and cinematic rather than strictly realistic. Character responses, supernatural motion and carefully timed environmental behavior reinforce the dark fable tone.

Production Approach

Signature moments receive bespoke animation, while reusable rigs and response sets are used where appropriate. Additional animator capacity is expected to be one of the first needs when production expands.

NARRATIVE

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NARRATIVE — KEY OBJECTIVES

A Define the opening Beast encounter, interrupted death, and the Witch's three masked manifestations.

B Write NPC dialogue and quest chains that unlock information, routes, assistance or complications inside later sequences.

C Define the Witch's voice, manipulation strategy and recurring role as the hidden figure the player must reach in each forest zone.

D Structure each chapter around exploration, local characters, finding the Witch, power progression and the Beast encounter that leads onward.

E Build a narrative and folklore reference guide that blends Latin American and Slavic inspiration without directly adapting one specific myth.

NARRA-TIVE

Worldbuilding & Lore

The story begins as a cautionary tale: an undefined wanderer becomes lost in the woods and crosses into a supernatural realm. The Beast represents their fated death, while the hidden Witch offers apparent salvation for motives of her own.

2026 Scope

The micro-demo must communicate the premise clearly: the Beast catches the player, death is interrupted by three masked manifestations of the Witch, and the player is sent into the forest to find her and learn how to change their fate.

Narrative Delivery

Narrative is delivered through cinematic branching dialogue, quests, character reactions, environmental storytelling and authored sequences.

Narrative Philosophy

The main story remains authored, while local choices change routes, information, favors and solutions. The goal is meaningful branching within chapters rather than an exponentially divergent campaign.

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ART

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ART

ART — KEY OBJECTIVES

A Lock the stylized 3D visual language: dark fantasy, whimsical fairy-tale elements, cel-shaded materials and an illustrated finish.

B Prioritize original 3D production for the Beast, Witch, key NPCs and the signature supernatural entities present in the vertical slice.

C Design the rune and material language that communicates which sequence elements resist the player’s powers.

D Unify purchased environment assets through custom materials, lighting, composition and signature original pieces.

E Refine UI and audiovisual feedback for dialogue, objectives, powers, Dread and sequence manipulation.

ART

Visual Language

The target is stylized 3D dark fantasy with the quality of an illustrated fable: a whimsical forest pushed into horror through cel-shaded materials, dramatic lighting and strong silhouettes.

Player & Interface Design

The protagonist remains visually undefined, keeping the folk-tale wanderer archetype flexible. UI must support cinematic dialogue, power energy, Dread feedback, objectives and clear readability without overwhelming the screen.

Environmental Identity

Each zone should feel like a distinct section of the same impossible forest. Original signature assets define identity, while purchased environment packs can support the vertical slice when unified through materials, lighting and composition.

Enemy & Entity Design

Priority original designs include the Beast, the Witch and her masks, key NPCs, and supernatural entities such as the spectral light guardian inspired by the Luz Mala concept.

THANK YOU.

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GET IN TOUCH WITH US

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